about to come to shove, neither Khrushchev nor the Presidium was willing to fight ‘a big war’ in defence of Cuba.

Washington’s relations with its allies were also illuminated by the crisis. Kennedy saw no need to consult with NATO when the missiles were discovered (though British officials were briefed three days after Kennedy learned about them and before his administration had decided how to react). During the public phase of the crisis (22-28 October) Kennedy’s phone conversations with Macmillan were a form of consultation. And on the crucial issue of whether to invade Cuba, the President specifically asked the Prime Minister for his opinion. Further, as Kennedy pondered whether or not to invade Cuba, he anxiously sought NATO’s support on how to deal with the Jupiter missiles.

Nonetheless, Kennedy expected US action against Cuba to provoke a Soviet response against West Berlin. But this did not lead him to consult NATO allies over the blockade, including those most closely involved with West Berlin’s security (who would be on the frontline if the crisis escalated into military conflict). And when it looked as though push might come to shove, Kennedy was prepared to strike a deal with Moscow that explicitly involved those allies being kept in the dark. ‘A scrupulous man is impractical in politics,’ so Anthony Trollope contended.[44]

The most dramatic statement concerning NATO remains that of Robert McNamara, who wrote that presidents Kennedy and Johnson shared his view that the US should never use nuclear weapons first, even though NATO strategy throughout the Cold War depended on the use of nuclear weapons against Soviet conventional attack. According to McNamara, the United States would not have risked national suicide to save Western Europe. If he is correct, the entire foundation of Western nuclear strategy was based on a calculated bluff.

Waiting for facts

After transmitting the go-code to the 843rd Bomb Wing, General Jack D. Ripper (memorably played by Sterling Hayden) sends a valedictory message to SAC Headquarters. It concludes: ‘God willing, we shall prevail